

Session 25: Jacob's Poem of Blessing Concludes

Key Takeaways

- Yaaqov's words for his sons often carry deep connections to the fate of their descendants in Joshua, Judges, and beyond.
- Dan's blessing could mean he will be a judge over the snake or a snake himself.
- Yoseph is set on analogy with Ishmael, recasting the division of Ishmael and Isaac as a story of reconciliation in this new generation and into Israel's future.

The Word About Zevulun

13 **Zevulun**, he dwells on the **coast of the sea**
and he is on **the coast of ships**,
his north part is by **Sidon**.

a 14 **Yissakhar**, he is a strong donkey
crouching down between the sheep pens.
b 15 And he saw a resting place, that it was **good**
and the land, that it was **pleasant**,
a' and he bowed his shoulder to carry
and he became a forced laborer

16 **Dan (דן)**, he will **judge (ידין)** his people
like one of the tribes of Yisra'el.
May **Dan (דן)** be **a snake** on the path,
a viper along the way,
which bites **the heel** of the horse,
so its rider falls backward.

18 **O Yahweh, I am waiting for your rescue!**

19 **Gad (גד)**, a troop (גדוד) will raid him (יגדנו)
and he will raid (יגד) **with the heel**.

20 From **Asher**, **rich** is his bread,
so he will give **delights** of a king.

21 **Naphtali**, a doe sent out,
who gives lovely lambs.

Genesis 49:13-21. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Yaaqov's word about Zevulun is linked to the region of the land where his descendants would settle in the days of Joshua and the judges (see [Josh. 19:10-16](#), [27](#), [34](#); [Judg. 1:30](#)).

The puzzle, however, is that in Joshua's days, Zevulun settled many miles inland from the northern coast of the Mediterranean. However, "dwelling" doesn't have to mean permanent land-holding. The blessing of Moses on Zebulun ([Deut. 33:18-20](#)) also links this tribe to the sea.

The Word About Yissakhar



IDF Mapping Unit. *The Twelve Tribes of Israel*, [Israel Ministry of Foreign Affairs](#)

This word also relates to the future land settlement of the tribe of Yissakhar. Their land holdings were right next to Zevulun, inland from the coast and south-west of the lake of Galilee (see [Josh. 17:10-11](#), [19:17-23](#)).

[Judges 1:19-34](#) makes clear that most of the tribes were not able to clear the land of its Canaanite inhabitants, and so they intermixed with them. This narrative omits any mention of Yissakhar at all, a fact which this poem appears to explore.

Yissakhar appears to have been a capable tribe ("a strong ass") but he did not use his strength. Rather, this tribe laid down passively (lazily?) among the sheep pens. Why? Because he found a nice resting place that came with a cost: slavery and oppression, precisely the status to which Yissakhar's kinsmen reduced the Canaanites in [Judges 1](#): "forced laborer" (לִמְסָר) = [Judges 1:28](#), [30](#), [33](#), [35](#).

The Word About Dan

The middle line of Yaaqov's poetic word about Dan is capable of two different interpretations, and both seem intended.

Option 1

Genesis 49:16-17 Instructor's Translation

¹⁶ Dan, he will judge his people
as one of the tribes of Israel.

¹⁷ **May there be a judge of the snake on the path**
a viper along the way
which bites the heels of the horse
so that its rider falls backward.

Option 2

Genesis 49:16-17 Instructor's Translation

¹⁶ Dan, he will judge his people
as one of the tribes of Israel.

¹⁷ **May Dan be a snake on the path**
a viper along the way
which bites the heels of the horse
so that its rider falls backward.

The translation issue revolves around the name “Dan” in the Hebrew phrase יהי דן נחש. The basic challenge is that the name Dan is the Hebrew word for “one who brings justice.”

This yields two possible meanings for Yaaqov’s words.

1. Option 1 anticipates a future Danite who will judge the snake!
2. Option 2 portrays Dan as a snake on a path.

The allusion to Genesis 3:15 is intentional, especially in light of the following word “viper” (שפיפון), which contains the consonants of the key word for “strike” in Genesis 3:15 (שוף).

Dan never settled in their allotted tribal territory (Josh. 19:47) due to Canaanite hostility (Josh. 1:34), so they migrated north of Galilee and settled there (see Josh. 18). They never held permanent land, and they were a small but tenacious tribe.

This tribe produced an important hero, whose story is cryptically anticipated in this poem: Samson in Judges 13-16.

- Samson was a Danite (Judg. 13:2), and his entire story depicts him as a deceiver who is deceived unto his own destruction, an anti-Genesis-3:15 figure. He is a wounded-victor, but he is deceived by his wife and suffers because of his own sins. The entire Samson narrative develops the “seed of the woman vs. snake” pattern from Genesis 3:15-16, which is anticipated here in riddle-like form.

Early Jewish Interpretations of Genesis 49:16-18

“16. From those of the house of Dan shall redemption arise, and a judge. Together, all the tribes of the sons of Israel shall obey him. 17. This shall be the redeemer who is to arise from the house of Dan; he will be strong, exalted above all nations. He will be compared to the serpent that lies on the ground, and to a venomous serpent that lies in wait at the crossroads, that bites the horses in the heels and out of fear of it the rider turns around and falls backward. He is Samson bar Manoah, the dread of whom is upon his enemies and the fear of whom is upon those who hate him. He goes out to war against those that hate him and kills kings together with rulers.” 18. Our father Jacob said: 'Not to the redemption of Gideon bar Joash does my soul look, which is the redemption of an hour; and not to the redemption of Samson bar Manoah does my soul look, which is a transient redemption. Rather to the redemption of him does my soul look that you have said to bring your people, the house of Israel. To you, to your redemption, do I look, O Lord.'”

McNamara, Martin, translator (1991). [*Targum Neofiti 1: Genesis \(The Aramaic Bible\)*](#). Liturgical Press.

“In blessing Dan, Jacob’s thoughts were occupied chiefly with his descendant Samson, who, like unto God, without any manner of assistance, conferred victory upon his people. Jacob even believed the strong, heroic man to be the Messiah, but when Samson’s death was revealed to him, he exclaimed, ‘I wait for Thy salvation, O Lord, for Thy help is unto all eternity, while Samson’s help is only for a time. The redemption,’ continued Jacob, ‘will not be accomplished by Samson the Danite, but by Elijah the Gadite, who will appear at the end of time.’”

Ginzberg, Louis (2003). [*Legends of the Jews \(2nd ed.\)*](#). Jewish Publication Society. 408.

The Cry for Deliverance

This line appears, somewhat surprisingly, as a first-person exclamation addressed not to the sons, but to Yahweh.

The phrase is a common liturgical one expressed in the Prophets and Psalms.

Psalms 25:5 NASB

Lead me in your truth and teach me,
for you are the God of my deliverance; for you I wait all the day.

Isaiah 25:9 NASB

And it will be said in that day,
“Behold, this is our God for whom we have waited that he might save us.
This is the LORD for whom we have waited;
let us rejoice and be glad in his deliverance.”

Isaiah 33:2 NASB

O LORD, be gracious to us; we have waited for you.
Be their strength every morning,
our deliverance also in the time of distress.

Notice that this line appears in the structural center of the entire chapter, in between two sets of poetic sayings about the brothers. But more specifically, it appears after the third poetic saying in the first two sets. Interestingly, those brothers feature Yehudah and Dan, both of whom are described as contrasting animals (lion vs. snake), and with imagery that recalls the Eden promise of [Genesis 3:15-16](#) about a future seed of the woman who will crush the snake and restore humanity's rule over the world.

If the above observations about the link between Yehudah and Dan are correct, that would place Yaaqov's cry for deliverance in a seventh position after the two sets of three poetic sayings. This is a common design strategy in biblical literature, to place a climactic seventh statement after a series of triads (like the seventh day after the six days of creation in [Genesis 1:1-2:3](#), or like the 10th Passover plague after the nine plagues of the Exodus in [Exodus 7-13](#)).

Triad #1	Triad #2
1. Reuven	4. Zevulun
2. Shimon and Levi	5. Yissakhar
3. Yehudah the lion !	6. Dan the snake !
7. "For your deliverance I wait, Yahweh!"	
<i>Two Triads of Jacob's Sons. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

The Word About Gad

This poem exploits the letters of Gad's name and their similarity with the Hebrew word *gedud*, which means "a unit of soldiers" (see this word in [1 Sam. 30:8, 15, 23](#); [2 Sam. 3:22](#); [2 Kgs. 6:23](#)), or the verb *gad*, "to raid."

This poem anticipates the role played by Gad (along with Reuven and half the tribe of Manasseh) in the conquest of the land: He will cross over and participate in the raid on Canaan ([Num. 32:16-32](#); [Deut. 3:18](#); [Josh. 1:12, 4:12](#)).

There is a translation challenge revolving around the meaning of "heel." Is it the (1) object of "raid" (i.e., Gad will be stomped by a raiding heel of an enemy army)? Or (2) an instrumental accusative, in which case this line joins with the poem about Dan—Gad also will produce one who "raids with the heel," which is another allusion to [Genesis 3:15](#).

The Word About Asher

The name "Asher" is formed from the Semitic root word "to declare someone is blessed with abundance" (see the word in other contexts in [Gen. 30:13](#); [Mal. 3:12](#); [Ps. 72:17](#)). And this "blessing" theme of Asher's name

evokes the Eden narrative, which will be drawn upon in this short poem.

This tribe settled west of Galilee in the fertile hills between Carmel and the coast where the Phoenicians were located (Josh. 19:24-31). The fertility of this region is reemphasized in Moses' blessing (Deut. 33:24).

The "delights" (מַעֲדֵן) are an allusion to Eden (עֵדֶן), but tragically this tribe will offer its Eden delights to the Canaanites, as recounted in Judges 1:13-21.

The Word About Naphtali

This tribe settled west of the lake of Galilee from its southern end up to Lake Huleh, north of the lake of Galilee (Josh. 19:32-39). They had to coexist with Canaanites they could not drive out, until they won a few cities for themselves (Judg. 1:33).

This tribe played an honorable role in the battle of Deborah because Barak, the Israelite general, was from Naphtali (Judg. 4:6, 5:18).

The final two words (lit. *'imrey shapher* / אִמְרֵי שֹׁפֵר) admit multiple interpretations.

1. "lovely words" = a herald of victory in the war of Deborah, see Judges 4:6, 10 and 5:18.
2. "lovely lambs/fawns" = tribute of animals to Canaanite overlords, just as "give" means offering tribute in the words spoken to Yissakhar (Gen. 49:15) and Asher (Gen. 49:20).
3. "lovely boughs" = metaphor of a spreading tree, an image of fruitfulness.

The Manifold Blessing on Yoseph

- 22 **Yoseph** is a son of a wild female donkey,
son of a wild donkey by a spring,
(sons of) wild donkeys by Shur.
- 23 They were hostile to him, and they **fired**,
and they were opposed to him, those **possessing arrows**.
- 24 But **his bow** remained perpetual,
and **the hands** of his arms were agile,

because of **the hands** of the **Strong One of Ya'akov**,
from there is the Shepherd, **the Rock of Yisra'el**,

- 25 from **the Elohim of your father**, who will help you,
and **Shaddai**, who will **bless** you:
blessings from heaven above
blessings from the deep, lying beneath
blessings of breast and womb,

²⁶ the **blessings** of your father, they are mighty
 above the **blessings** of the **mountains**
 up to the desire of **eternal hills** .
 These will be upon **the head** of **Yoseph** ,
 on **the crown** of one set apart from his brothers.

Genesis 49:22-26. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

The opening line of the poem about Yoseph is a riddle filled with Hebrew words capable of more than one meaning. This produces an “overabundance of possible meaning” that matches the theme of the poem, which is about a son given an overabundance of favor and abundance. Here are two possible translations alongside one another; both meanings are intended.

Possible Meaning 1

Genesis 49:22-24 Instructor's Translation

²² Yoseph is a son of a wild female donkey,
 son of a wild donkey by a spring,
 (sons of) wild donkeys by Shur.
²³ They were hostile to him, and they **fired,**
 and they were opposed to him, those **possessing arrows.**
²⁴ But **his bow remained perpetual,**
 and **the hands** of his arms were agile

Yoseph is compared to a young male donkey (a foal), born to a wild female donkey, which finds itself by a desert spring on the way to Shur, a desert oasis stop south of the land promised to Abraham (see [Gen. 16:7](#) and [20:7](#)).

This meaning uses the key words “wild female donkey” (פרת // פרא), “spring” (עין), and “Shur” (שור) to recall the stories of Hagar and Ishmael, comparing them to Rachel and Yoseph.

- Recall that in [Genesis 16:7](#), Hagar flees from Sarai to a spring (עין) on the way to Shur (שור), and she hears from an angel that her son will be a “wild donkey” (פרא) of a human.
- Recall that in [Genesis 20:7](#), Ishmael and Hagar live in the wilderness where he “is a shooter of the bow” (רבה קשת).

The reference to a hostile “they” in 49:23 would then refer to Yoseph’s jealous older brothers, activating the brothers // Esau analogy (see [Gen. 27:41](#), “And Esau was hostile (שטם) to Yaaqov”).

On this reading, Yoseph is the blessed and chosen younger brother who unlocks the divine blessings of Eden for others, but he was persecuted by his elder brothers and chased into the wilderness like Ishmael. But God kept Yoseph’s arms stable and blessed him with cosmic blessing (skies and abyss = [Gen. 1](#) vocabulary).

Possible Meaning 2

Genesis 49:22-24 Instructor's Translation

22 Yoseph is a son of a fruit-bearing (tree),
 a fruit-bearing (tree) by a spring,
 daughters striding over a wall.

23 They were hostile to him, and they **fired,**
 and they were opposed to him, those **possessing arrows.**

24 But **his bow** remained perpetual,
 and **the hands** of his arms were agile

Yoseph is compared to a branch from a fruit-bearing tree (literally “son of a fruit-bearer”) that is located by a spring, with tendril-runners (literally “daughters”) that climb over walls to spread their fruitfulness outside the garden.

- “Son of a fruit-bearer” is a possible way the images could be understood, and so Yoseph would be compared to a fruit-tree bearing much fruit (i.e., Yaaqov and Rachel).
- The “spring” would be the gift of Yahweh’s blessing on the chosen ones.
- The “wall” would represent the overabundance of God’s fruitful blessing, so that even a garden wall can’t contain the blessing as it spreads out of its original area of planting.
- These Eden images are so rooted in the narrative of [Genesis 2-3](#), as well as the Eden imagery activated by Yoseph’s rule over his family in the land of Goshen (which is an Eden place), it is unlikely that these possible meanings were not in the mind of the poet.

The Royal Blessing on Yoseph

The blessing given to Yoseph recalls the blessing given to Yaaqov by his father Isaac in [Genesis 27](#). This similarity makes it clear that Yoseph is being marked as the firstborn among all the sons.

Genesis 49:25-26 Yaaqov’s Blessing on Yoseph	from the Elohim of your father , who will help you, and Shaddai, who will bless you: blessings from the skies above blessings from the deep, lying beneath blessings of breast and womb, the blessings of your father , they are mighty above the blessings of the mountains up to the desire of eternal hills. These will be upon the head of Yoseph , on the crown of one set apart from his brothers .
Genesis 27:27-29 Isaac’s Blessing on Yaaqov	See, the smell of my son, like the smell of the field, which Yahweh has blessed. May Elohim give to you from the dew of the skies, and from the fat of the land,
<i>Symmetry in Blessing of Joseph and Jacob. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).</i>	

and much grain and new wine.
 May peoples serve you,
 and may people groups **bow down to you** ,
 be a mighty one to your brothers,
 and may the **sons of your mother** bow down to you.
 Cursed are those who curse you,
 and those who blessed you are **blessed**.

Symmetry in Blessing of Joseph and Jacob. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

It's clear that Yoseph is inheriting the divine blessing of abundance that has marked the promised lineage from Abraham to Isaac to Yaaqov.

- Notice the echoes of Genesis 1:1-2 ("skies," "the deep," the land") and also of the human image of Elohim who is "set apart" from the animals to a place of blessing and rule.
- Now that Yoseph and Yehudah have each received their blessings, notice that the two aspects of the image of Elohim from Genesis 1 have here been allotted to two special sons of Yaaqov.

Genesis 1:27-28

Elohim created human in his own image,
 in the image of Elohim he created him;
 male and female he created them.

And Elohim **blessed** them;
 and Elohim said to them,

"Be fruitful and multiply,
and fill the land, and subdue it;
and rule over the fish of the sea and over the birds of the sky
 and over every living thing that moves on the earth."

Yehudah
Eden abundance
A ruler among the sons of Yisrael
A ruler among the nations

Yoseph
Eden abundance
Royal status among the sons of Yisrael

Comparing Judah and Joseph. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).

Both sons are given the Eden blessing of abundance and of royal rule among the brothers. Only Yehudah is assigned a place of rule outside of the family of Israel. This dual blessing sets up the reader for the long history of rivalry that will plague these two tribes, which will come to dominate Israel's story in the land. It is the tribe of Yoseph's son Ephrayim who will become the most powerful and numerous in the north, and the tribe of Yehudah will dominate in the south.

This division in the age of the patriarchs is a preview of the division that will take place after David and Solomon's death ([1 Kings 1-2](#) and [11](#)). The kingdom of "Yisrael and Yehudah" will split into north and south, and Rehoboam and Jeroboam will become the descendants who replay the rivalry of their ancestors (see [1 Kings 12-14](#)).

The Word About Binyamin

27 **Binyamin**, a wolf who will tear.
In the morning he devours,
and in the evening he divides plunder.

28 All these are the twelve tribes of **Yisra'el**,
and this is what **their father** said to them,
and he **blessed** them,
each according to his **blessing**,
he **blessed** them.

Genesis 49:27-28. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022)

Here the tribe of Binyamin is portrayed as aggressive and powerful, which is pretty much the opposite of his passive and powerless portrait in [Genesis 42-46](#).

The aggressive nature of the sons of Binyamin are a core theme of Judges-Samuel.

- Ehud ([Judg. 3:15](#))
- The warriors of Binyamin in the battle of Deborah ([Judg. 5:14](#))
- The notoriously accurate slingshot warriors of Binyamin ([Judg. 20:15-16](#)) who fought savagely in the Israelite civil war described in [Judges 20](#)

The territory of this tribe occupied the central location between Yehudah in the south and Ephraim in the north ([Josh. 18:11-20](#)), as well as the main road from east of the Jordan to the western Mediterranean—i.e., it was the arena of many wars throughout Israel's history.

We can detect allusions to Saul in this poem. Israel's first king was from Binyamin, and his downfall was precisely in his aggressive "eating" of the "plunder" in [1 Samuel 14:30-32](#) and [15:19-21](#).

Notice that the sequence of sons corresponds to the symmetrical arrangement of the triads and to the distribution of animal imagery in the poems. Yehudah and Binyamin occupy matching positions as the conclusion to the first and last triad, pairing the imagery of lion versus wolf. Recall that David and Saul were from the tribes of Yehudah (lion) and Binyamin (wolf).

1. Reuven 2. Shimon and Levi 3. Yehudah the lion!	A
1. Zevulun 2. Yissakhar the donkey 3. Dan the snake	B
"For your deliverance I wait, Yahweh!"	
1. Gad 2. Asher 3. Naphtali the deer	B'
Yoseph the wild donkey 1. Ephrayim 2. Manasseh 3. Binyamin the wolf	A'
Judah and Benjamin the Animals. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: Joseph (2022).	

Reflection Question

What are some implications of the links between Yoseph and Ishmael in Yaaqov's poem of blessing in Genesis 49:22-26?